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Jerry Bergonzi

Jerry Bergonzi is a highly-respected saxophonist, composer, and jazz educator. He has recorded frequently as a leader of his own groups, and was a member of the Dave Brubeck Quartet from 1979-1981. Jerry is the author of two jazz method books, Inside Improvisation, *and* Sound Advice, *and teaches at the New England Conservatory of Music.*

Jerry was interviewed via Zoom on June 7, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I am at Hamilton College and Jerry Bergonzi, I assume you're in Boston?

JB: Yeah, well right outside of Boston in Medfield, Massachusetts, yup.

MR: I'm going to introduce you as an awesome tenor player and a highly respected jazz educator. How's that?

JB: Sounds great to me.

MR: How did you make it through the real intense Covid years? Are you a kind of person that can happily fill that time with practice?

JB: You know I'm going to tell you what happened. My whole life I've been traveling. Travel, travel, travel, travel. So this is the first time in my life I haven't had to travel and I loved it. I love being home. Free time — I get to practice, write songs, you know play the drums, play the piano, play the saxophone, chase my wife around the house you know. Of course I'm joking but you get what I'm saying? It's wonderful. I didn't have to travel.

MR: Nice. And you're a — I read you're a bassist, or you were.

JB: Yeah, I played bass, yup.

MR: Yeah. Did that, in retrospect, help you with hearing chords and figuring out chords, just being more tuned into the music as being the fact that you played the bass?

JB: Yes. Well that and how to hook up with the drums, you know, how to play time and where to put the beat. That is even more crucial, of course because I played piano I'm hearing the chords and with my left hand I can play bass notes. But hearing the dialogue or the interaction between the bass and the drums, which plays more on top, which is behind with the role, you know, and that really helped me with that just to recognize it and to give it a name.

MR: As a saxophone player, have you had instances where the bassist and the drummer seem to not be on the same page as far as where is the groove? Where is the beat? And how do you deal with that?

JB: Well the first thing, the answer to the first part of the question, of course I recognize that that certain drummers sound great with certain bass players. There's a marriage made in heaven with some, and then there's ones that might be great players with other drummers or bass players but they don't seem to play together great. So without saying names, you know, so for me my role is to be flexible. I need to like be able to play with this type of rhythm section, with that type of rhythm section. So I always think where should I — how should I go about — you know usually a lot of this is answered unconsciously. But sometimes I think yeah, I'm going to play more on top because — or that's what they're playing so I'm going to play more on top of the beat, or I can really lay back with this rhythm section and they won't drag. Because sometimes if I lay back too much the rhythm section starts dragging. I know there's a story that Joe Hunt, I heard about Joe Hunt playing with Dexter and he said the first set that he played of a two week engagement that it really dragged and he realized for the rest of the two weeks he couldn't listen to Dexter, he just had to play time. You know? I get it.

MR: I used to think that — imagine being a piano player with like Billie Holiday and making this judgement well do I go with her? Do I play where she's at or do I just like straight ahead?

JB: Yeah.

MR: You talked about being on the road forever, and if you did one of those gigs like we had you come up here to Utica, New York and we lined up a rhythm section, is there a short list of tunes that you would call first to sort of try to gauge what you were dealing with?

JB: Well if I didn't know the rhythm section at all, yeah maybe I would get a few standards that I would play and you know, but no different than anybody else would do. "It Could Happen to You," maybe "On Green Dolphin Street" or a ballad or something like that, "I Can't Get Started" or you know I'd play a tune like that, but usually they tell me, "Yeah Jerry, send us some of your tunes" and I'll send it to them and that sort of thing.

MR: So it's not usually like shake hands with the band when you get there and count off the first time.

JB: Usually they want some music beforehand. "What are we going to play, Jerry? What are we going to play?" So you know I want to make everybody comfortable so I'll just think on the spot let's try this, let's try that. You know.

MR: Do you feel that jazz chose you somehow? I read that you had an uncle that was one flight up from you, yeah, and was a jazz musician. So I'm wondering if you had other choices when you were a kid? Do you have other passions that you sort of had to decide one or the other?

JB: You know I might be a boring person to answer this but I didn't. You know? I mean I just

didn't take it seriously. Yeah it was something I was just doing. And my first record was a little Lester Young record with Count Basie you know, those recordings. "Tickle Toe" and the Kansas City Six or Seven, I forget what it is. And then I started some other Count Basie, Duke Ellington records, and then I got a small — but right from the get-go I was listening to that. And then a friend, when I was twelve a friend of mine came over my house and his father was a trumpet player and he had a Miles record with Coltrane on it, and a Sonny Rollins record and an Art Blakey record with Wayne Shorter on it. I said oh my goodness. So that's when I really got the bug.

MR: Don't you think it's necessary to have that serious bug to go into jazz these days?

JB: Yeah I do. And you can even have a bug but if you have other bugs that you know, so, a friend of mine, Adam Nussbaum, always says, "You know there's only one reason you should get into jazz, 'cause you can't help it. There's nothing — that's just it." 'Cause if you have choices, take the other choice.

MR: You know some other people have said that including Phil Woods, you know, you going to be a doctor or a jazz musician, hmmm.

JB: Yeah. I always tell people you've got to have a way to support your — especially in these days — your I'll call it a jazz habit but it could be a music habit — a way to support yourself. You know because the gigs are fewer, they pay the same that they paid forty years ago, and you used to be able to make a living, not a great living but playing. But today it's next to impossible.

MR: Was that one of the reasons that you got into teaching? To support your gig habit so to speak?

JB: Yeah. I got into teaching because I didn't want to play any gigs I didn't want to play anymore. You know I didn't want to play weddings and I didn't want to play with groups that are so loud you can't even hear a note you're playing, you know rock groups or — I'd just rather be talking about the music I love and teaching it rather than doing something else. Yeah. And I found that people liked my pedagogy, the way I taught it, so it was natural for me.

MR: Did you have to do some serious — well let me rephrase. I'm going to guess that maybe you started teaching a few private lessons and then to move to a university level did you have to codify some of your own methods and prove to some committee that you were worthy of being there?

JB: Actually no I didn't. I had already codified a lot of — because I had, when I moved back to Boston after leaving Dave Brubeck in 1981, the end of '81, I put up little flyers and in a short amount of time I had a two year waiting list. Two years. And if you want to study with me okay you can but you're on a list, two years. And it really was a two year

study with me — and not all of them but most of them you know, and they're teaching my stuff and I didn't even think about it. This is what I teach. And the only reason I was good at it was because I taught myself. Nobody showed me so I had to learn how to play. And it's the only thing I wanted to do is be a better player. So I would get systems for myself to practice. But then Berklee called me up and offered me a position for low bread. And I said I don't even have to leave my apartment, I've got a two year waiting list, I don't have to pay for parking and I'm getting paid more. I'm good. New England Conservatory called me up and said, "Jerry what do you want?" I said this. They said, "Okay, no problem." So and that's not a put down for Berklee. At the time that's just where they were at you know.

MR: You mentioned that you mostly taught yourself and I read, and I believe this is from your web page. You said, "Many of the veterans of the period when you were learning were not inclined to mentor newcomers. Back then if somebody knew they weren't going to tell you." Is that an accurate reading?

JB: I would say so. They'd say, "Oh man I don't know what I'm doing, you know, just listen to records, learn tunes, listen to records, learn tunes." I had the greatest saxophone teacher in the world, Joe Viola at Berklee that when I was in high school, tenth, eleventh, twelfth grade that's who I studied with. And he would play piano and we'd play tunes. "Hey Joe what's this, what is that, what is this flat nine here is that a — you know. So he was the greatest but he never said, you know, we just play together and sometimes we'd listen to music together but he was great at etudes and practice — how to play the saxophone, the right technique. And as soon as you heard him play you were a believer. Because he just — and I'd practice on the tenor saxophone all week long. I'd come in he'd transpose it on alto he would never make a mistake. And here I am goofing up. He was just, you know, amazing. And I was in John LaPorta's Youth Band at the Greater Boston area. Joe got me into that and a featured soloist in the band. But nobody said practice this, practice that. It was just like hey let me figure this out, let me figure that out. I remember calling up Wayne Shorter one time asking him for lessons. He said he didn't give lessons but —

MR: So now you tell your students what to practice. People weren't telling you but you tell them. Is that too simplistic?

JB: No but a few words in there that I would change and I suggest what to practice. I don't tell anybody anything. I mean — you know what I mean? I say if you do this, this is really going to help. But I always leave the decision whether they want to practice or not. I tell them I don't really care if you practice. I don't care if you get better. And as a matter of fact I practice 'cause I don't care if I get better. I practice because I like

emotionally, spiritually, mentally. If you don't want to practice cool. You know I mean what can I tell you?

MR: And they're paying a hefty sum to be there.

JB: Bingo.

MR: And so there's some motivation there.

JB: Yeah.

MR: I want to read — I know there's a discussion that happens about original sound etcetera. I want to read two very short quotes from — this is the generation before you and I. This is from Billy Mitchell. He said "There's a lot of youngsters get caught up in the proficiency and the musicality and they forget the emotion. The emotion takes longer. You have to experience it." And from Harry "Sweets" Edison, "Our ambition in my day not to be an imitator but an originator, and they used to say they'd rather be the world's worst originator than the world's greatest imitator. Nowadays it seems like musicians have their idols and they don't venture anyplace else but what their idol is playing." Do you have any comment?

JB: I agree with both of those things but in one — the first one was Billy Taylor you said?

MR: Billy Mitchell.

JB: Billy Mitchell, sorry, yup. Billy Mitchell. The first thing I would say was that sometimes people when they come into this life they come in with heavy baggage. So they don't even need to experience a lot of emotional stuff, they already have it, depending on their upbringing. They have their mother and father were fighting all the time or they were in a poverty situation. So their experience, their soul is already, you know they say the soul picks the lifetime, right? So I don't necessarily think that you need to get your life experience to the life you're living, you already have it, even though you're getting it in this life, you already came in with something.

MR: Are you hinting at reincarnation?

JB: Yes.

MR: Okay.

JB: And the other thing is would I rather be the worst…

MR: Originator.

JB: …originator than a really good copy cat. That's a fantastic thing because in today's world nobody learns how to play by walking out of a cave one day and they learn how to play. You have to know the history of this. You listen to early John Coltrane you can hear Dexter Gordon in it, you can hear Sonny Rollins in it, you can hear Jimmy Heath, you can hear of course Charlie Parker in everybody. But you know etcetera, etcetera. And then you can hear later Dexter and there's some Coltrane things in there you know. So

there for sure and Newk that he tips his hat to. And early Sonny Rollins if there's no Charlie Parker there's no Sonny Rollins. Just the language. So everybody's getting something from somebody. At a certain point you say I breathe I'm valid. I'm going to listen to myself and try to do, get my sound — you don't even have to try. You can't get away from your sound even if you try to sound like somebody else you're just going to end up sounding like you trying to sound like somebody else. So you say yeah, I'm going to be more me. And believe in yourself. I tell my students if I could tell you one thing believe in yourself. You are valid.

MR: What happens when a student uses the "if only I had a better mouthpiece, a different horn, I can't find a reed that works"?

JB: I tell them that that's — they're on the wrong channel. You know you go to the gig, I tell them I go to the gig and I'm playing, the microphone, it's too much treble, the reverb it's not enough reverb. And I say oh that's the wrong channel. I have to go back to the music channel you know, or the drums are too loud. Just keep turning it back to the music channel. You know? We all have that. It's the mind. And you know how they say the mind is a terrible thing to waste on drugs? I don't go that far. See the mind is a terrible thing. End of sentence.

MR: In other words like don't overthink it, ey?

JB: Yeah. Don't think it. Don't overthink.

MR: I was — I saw another interview with you which I was happy that I landed on, and you were talking about the four elements and it reminded me that I had this interesting interview with Gary Smulyan. And he had four elements of music but they were different from yours. So before I talk about his, would you mind telling me that again?

JB: Sure. In astrology and metaphysics there's four elements. There's earth, fire, water, and air. And there's three fire signs, there's three air signs, there's three water signs and three earth signs in the twelve signs of the zodiac. Fire of course is energy. It could be scorched earth energy or it could be warm fire or a cool fire you know. It could be the fire of intuition. It could be the fire of — and air is intellect. And whatever frequency your mind is at I mean it could be higher mind, lower mind, you know from thinking about you know eating all day is different than thinking of how to — not that that's bad because you know nutrition is important, but how to invent a cure for cancer, you know, things like that. So water is emotion. And the higher is inspiration. That's — you know you're getting inspired and it comes from the emotional body, where intellect is intuition. That's the higher aspect of the mental body. And earth is groove. It's time. It's how to play your instrument. It's like you know I've got to bring these inspiration and intuition down and make it on this planet earth. That's earth. Earth signs. So everybody has all four to some

words but sometimes it gives you what you hear and you say yeah, this guy really has a lot of air or this guy is so emotional but maybe could use a little bit of this or that, whatever.

MR: When you listen to yourself does it occur to you that you could use a little more or a little less of something?

JB: Yeah. Sometimes I'm thinking like yeah it's like I was burning too hot. You know too much fire in that. I'm just going to learn the less I play the better I like it, the more I like it. You know things like that or I think yeah there's something missing here. I'll think like that. I won't necessarily — yeah I need more air, I need more water. No, it's more in a musical terms.

MR: I see. Gary Smulyan said his four were: what you can think, what you can hear, what you can feel and what you can execute.

JB: It sounds similar, doesn't it?

MR: Yes it does indeed. It's just a different way of putting it.

JB: Execute is earth, right?

MR: Yeah.

JB: Hear is water. What you — say the other ones again?

MR: What you can think.

JB: Yeah, that's air.

MR: Yeah and what you can hear.

JB: Yup.

MR: What you can feel, which I guess would be like —

JB: Water.

MR: Yeah. Well I'm glad we solved that.

JB: Yeah.

MR: So if you believe that souls find a body and continue on, did you ever get any hint about what soul might have been passed to you? What kind of soul?

JB: Yeah. The way you said the sentence is, to me, what soul passed to me. It's like my soul, which they say souls are eternal and they say that they have hundreds of lifetimes. And you have to experience, this is the great teachers talking about reincarnation. You have to be a saint and you have to be a sinner. One lifetime you could be a hooker, the next lifetime you're a doctor. You know you have to learn all the different aspects of life to get to the place where you don't have to come back here anymore or whatever. But I don't know about that stuff I'm just — that's what they say. But have I had an inkling of past lifetimes? Yes I have. What I've meditated I kind of said yeah, wow. I just get an intuition about it you know.

JB: Well I can remember studying the stars in Peru and I'd even see the shape of the windows that I was — I mean where I'd go look at it, investigating. It was exactly what I saw. And another one I remember a woman who used to — I used to go to a psychic and she said to me, "You're going to go on four trips this year but one's getting canceled because one of the people in the band — you're going overseas four times this year but one of the guys in the band is going to get sick." And one of the guys did get sick, Dave's son, and we canceled the trip. Dave Brubeck's son. And she said, "You were a piano player in another life" which doesn't surprise me you know. Things like that.

MR: Um hum. Very interesting. The other day I heard John Coltrane's "A Love Supreme" part of it. They played part of it on Sirius radio. And I started thinking about the certain decades of jazz. And it seems like for much of jazz there was a social connection that went with the music and I'm not sure I'm correct about this but in the 30s you had a dance and entertainment element. In the 50s — when I think of the 50s I think of you know there's this sort of hipster — Dizzy Gillespie with the beret, like there's a hip-jiveness to it. And then in the 60s you had a Civil Rights element and a lot of spirituality. And I think about the current times now and I don't know what is the — is there a social aspect connected to jazz that is recognizable?

JB: Yeah. People often ask me where is jazz going. And I said you need to ask young people because they have their finger on the pulse of the music. They know everything is coming out, they know that. So I don't know if I'm even qualified to answer that. And I agree with you about the 60s. In a joking way I say yeah the jazz universe peaked in '65 you know. When everybody was alive and well. You know, Ben Webster was alive and well. Coleman Hawkins was alive and well. Sonny Rollins doing his thing. John Coltrane raging. The Miles Davis Quintet. You know everybody is alive and well. The avante garde alive and well. The swing guys, the bebop guys, the hard hop guys. You know? Alive and well and playing this great music. And being a student of it, I didn't differentiate well this is hip, that's not that hip, this is — you know. But today everything is in retrospect. You know these people in those schools aren't — they're not alive, a lot of these players. So it's a different, and not to mention the iPhone and the computers. You know you want to sound like Clifford Brown? There's probably every song he's ever played already transcribed. Here's his favorite licks, his favorite — this is what he practiced. The same thing with John Coltrane of course, Joe Henderson and Sonny Rollins. It's there on a silver platter. And you want this recording? Yes, easy to get. You can have every record on a little thumb drive. You know? Whereas back in my day you couldn't get all the recordings you know. And somebody said to me, "Yeah and back in my generation we listened to one recording a thousand times. Today you listen to a

playing music for social reasons I wonder. But I can say this though the world has gone so materialistic. How many things can they have? Let's get some more things. Things, things, things. But for musicians, just to play music, that's pretty amazing.

MR: But we had things that made us — gave us a connection to the artist. We had the LPs, we had the liner notes, we carried our LPs around in milk crates wherever we went, and there was something about having that possession that you had to work for, at least for me, it was an important part of playing music or being engaged.

JB: Yes. Yeah. You know I just sold my record collection 'cause half of it was missing, people borrowing it and never returning it. Because I grew up in Watertown, Mass. and one short bus ride I could be in Harvard Square and I'd go to this place called Briggs and Briggs. And it was a record shop and they had three listening booths. And I'd get a stack of records every week — or every two weeks, and I'd always buy two or three of them so they never gave me a hard time — "Oh he's in there again listening." So I was getting all the Blue Notes, the Prestige, the Impulse when they were coming out, you know all the ones that people — I'd go ga-ga over. But yeah, I just found myself, you know between replacing the needles and doing all this, I said yeah, I don't need this. Plus they were scratched to hell because a lot of times I'd be, you know when I'd transcribe I'd put the needle — oh let me get that. Because I'd just play along with records all day.

MR: You got the bug.

JB: Yeah.

MR: That's very interesting to me because I did the same thing but a lot of times I was the person in the rock band who needed to write out the horn parts so I remember that you know, dropping the needle and —

JB: Exactly.

MR: That's a pretty good ear training practice right there.

JB: Yes. You've got to do it quick.

MR: Yeah. I think I read something that made me think of Don Menza, some anecdote about you being in a practice room at a college and someone telling you to get out of there so someone could play some serious music.

JB: That's true. That's Dr. Edward Gildane. That's not a put down because he looked in the room, opened the door and said, "I'm giving you the hairy eyeball. Let somebody serious about music practice in here." Now having said that, if I went back in time and listened to myself practice I would have thrown myself out, you know? But you've got to start somewhat, you know what I mean?

MR: Yeah. Well Don went to SUNY Fredonia at the time they didn't have jazz. And he made a crack that playing Dixieland was a misdemeanor and playing bebop was a felony.

MR: So I was getting in to — some of your pedagogy of course is on line. I'm not sure it's on line on purpose or if people have, you know.

JB: I've given up even thinking about it.

MR: Right. It doesn't bode well to think about it. But there was a thing you had, it was a bebop scale #2 and you were talking about playing bebop scales over the bar line. And I thought it was pretty interesting. And near the end you said, "I'm going to do this, it's going to be boring but hey it's practice." So my question, how do you take those techniques like playing bebop scales over bar lines, put them into improvised solos and make them not boring?

JB: Yeah. Well that's where the artist comes in. You know there's the — you can mix up the paints and try this color and that color but after a while you've just got to say, you have to forget all that. Forget everything you know, that sort of thing, and paint a picture. So I heard a quote once that Charlie Parker said, I don't know if this is true or not, it doesn't matter because I like the story. He says it takes you ten years to learn how to play, it takes you another ten to forget what you learned. So the mind, you can't use — they asked Sonny Rollins, what do you think about when you play? He said, "You can't do that." Yeah. And so when you're playing, I'm only thinking of doing those sorts of things in the practice room so I might hear them when I'm playing or intuit them more because in a split second it's already gone you know? So those are things you practice so they might come to you in your playing but you're not thinking about it when you're playing. You don't have time.

MR: I'd like to ask more about that but I'm not sure how to ask it. If you've got these techniques in your head and then do they become in your hands? Do they happen without you thinking about them?

JB: Well great question. I heard the story that when Miles was playing at the Plugged Nickel the band got together and said, "Let's play what we don't hear." And that doesn't mean, like you were saying Gary Smulyan said you know play what you hear. They're not saying that. But there's certain things that naturally you would play, the first onslaught of ideas. Don't play those. Wade through it all and get to something in the back there that's a little different, a little — that's one thing. So the other thing that I think of when you said that, if you're practicing doing foul shots in a basketball team or dribbling, when you're dribbling down the floor and some defender's coming at you you're not thinking well I'm going to pass this to my left hand. It's just automatic. Same thing with shooting, it's automatic. So all things are helping you to be more automatic if you choose to be.

MR: Can you imagine being in a situation and you're improvising and you are distracted. Let's say you've parked your car for wherever this gig is and you think it could be towed away.

JB: Well if it came to my car being towed away no.

MR: Okay. Let me dial back on that. There's someone noisy at the bar.

JB: "Excuse me, man, I've got to move my car." You know? A solo I could do anytime but getting your car towed? I'm going to take care of business.

MR: Okay. I guess what I'm after is you know noisy nightclub.

JB: Oh yeah. I don't even pay attention to them. My attitude is you don't bother me, I don't bother you. Some people get really annoyed. We used to play with Hal Galper. He'd stop the band and he'd get on the microphone and say, "I can hear you, can you hear me?" And I get that. That's his way to do it. For me I'd just concentrate more on the music. If these people are spending money to come, if they want to talk go ahead. It's just personally as long as — I hope it's not too loud but even if it is probably you start playing louder.

MR: Of course the people that are complaining have sat right down in front of the band.

JB: Yeah. And they are clueless. They think that yeah, this is cool, I'm talking. I'm trying to have a conversation here. What's he doing up there playing? I get it.

MR: I enjoyed listening to a tune that you wrote that you entitled, "Awake."

JB: "Awake." Yeah.

MR: Yes. Do you mind telling that anecdote and led you to that title?

JB: Yeah, there's a story of Buddha meditating on top of a mountain and all the villages in the bottom of the mountain could see this light, faint but still — this light at the top of the mountain. And every day the light got a little stronger until one day the light started descending down the mountain. And it turns out it's Buddha. And a villager walks up and says, "Are you God?" "No." "Are you a saint?" "No." "Are you a prophet?" "No." What are you?" "I'm awake. Just present. Awake." So I named a tune after that story.

MR: I liked the way you said you looked over at the piano player and said, "This is a 'Stolen Moments' [misquote: "Moment's Notice"] change. What do we call that? A contrafact?"

JB: Yeah.

MR: I just loved that. Because I hadn't heard that word until I'd been playing music for like forty years.

JB: Me either. I mean contrafact, I never heard the term "contrafact." So I don't call them contrafacts, I call them counterfeits.

MR: Oh man. Then when you said that — awake — I think of well there's a current term now called "woke."

JB: Woke.

MR: "Are you woke?"

JB: Are you woke? What does woke mean? Are you a liberal?

JB: Yeah. I'm a radical liberal.

MR: Good for you.

JB: I like music. I think the election wasn't stolen. I think that it was a big insurrection and yeah, I'm not — and I think people should have the right to vote, it shouldn't be like make it harder for people to vote, they should make it easier for people to vote. Is that being woke? I don't know. If it is I guess I'm woke.

MR: Should be kind of the thing to be, you would think. And which sort of leads me to a question I don't always ask but when you look at the state of the country right now how do you feel about it?

JB: Okay. Could we talk? There's a thing called — and maybe you'll look this up when we finish. It's called Pluto Return USA. When the United States's Declaration of Independence was written in the time, there's an astrology chart for it. And the astrology chart, Pluto which rules death, transformation, Plutocrats, Pluto takes 246 or '48 years to go through the Zodiac and before it even gets to the exact spot you're feeling it four, five years before and you'll feel it three years after. Because it hits that spot three times. And it's here now. And you can tell. It's the death of democracy where oligarchs with money in politics, with ruling elections, with saying the elections were stolen even though the courts said no, that's not true. Fox News spouting all this stuff. I mean, and Pluto Return rules transformation — and it pulls out in all the corners of the room and cleans out all the stuff, and it's going to happen this week. First of all it happened exactly, it's 27 degrees, 33 minutes Capricorn, that's where Pluto was. And that happened February 21st. But it took five years for it to lead up to it, and Donald Trump and the Republicans, or the Demo — anybody whose corrupt, criminal. I'm not saying it's just Republicans, even Democrats. Whoever. It's cleaning house. I hope it works. And it wasn't until the second, the Roman Empire wasn't until the second Pluto Return that that folded. Pluto returned and did away with Napoleon. Pluto returned and did away with Stalin and the U.K. It's here.

MR: Can we live through it?

JB: Well I'm hoping that out of the ashes of the dead self rises the phoenix, that's what they say, and that's what a Pluto Return could be. And let's see if we have enough spiritual guidance in this country to get us there because the forces of materialism are just so strong. It's like it's a battle. That's why music is so important. That's why all musicians have a balancing out, all that stuff, to do something because you love it, because you just love it. It doesn't matter how good you are. You know it's music. It's great.

MR: You just answered the question I was trying to form in my head, so thank you. I mean you take refuge in your music. Does it inspire you to compose?

JB: Yes. It inspires me to compose. One of the things that I've done, and you asked me at the beginning about Covid. When Covid first started I was getting on Zoom and I was playing with a drummer from Germany, a bass player from Malmo, Sweden, a piano player from Newton, right outside of Boston. And we tried to play. Of course because of the latency we couldn't play time so we played things that were out of time or sometimes the drummer would say, "Oh man, you're two beats in front of me" so I would try to anticipate the changes by two beats and make it sound normal to him. But then I said I'm going to do some livestreams. And to make a long story short, I've been doing livestreams for a year and a half now. I've done 309 of my tunes, originals as well as 40 of a friend of mine's and the drummer had maybe 30 of his tunes. And every week we play different tunes. But now because I ran out of tunes I'm starting to do repeats.

MR: That's like an inspiration and a compelling thing right there, like I've got this way of presenting this stuff it's time to write something new.

JB: Yes.

MR: How do you start? How do you start writing something new?

JB: I get a little idea. For example I might think of a little rhythm, I might think of a harmonic device, a melodic — a shape of a melody — and say I'm going to write this melody, just the shape, and I could do the chords as I go along or I might even do it to a standard tune or whatever. So every tune I write has a different — sometimes I think I'm going to write this tune just using four intervals, that's it. I'm going to write this tune with a lot of space. I'm going to write a lot of major — non-conventional harmony or you know, that sort of thing. But you know out of 309 tunes that I just got through, and of course I have written so many more than that but those are the only ones I felt like playing, every one of them there's not like — they're all different. They all have a little — they're just little improvisations. And what I tell my students, I said, "If I told you right now I'm going to give you ten thousand dollars if you could write five tunes in two hours" you'd write five tunes in two hours. And that's the attitude. Don't care if they're good, just write them.

MR: Don't care if they're good, just write them.

JB: Just write them. If I try to write the perfect tune I'll end up spending two months, I'll end up with a tune I don't even like that much. Little improvisations.

MR: I see.

JB: And if Herbie Hancock played any — they would sound like the greatest tune ever. And you know but if you can get the greatest tune that was ever written and give it to a student maybe it might not sound that good you know.

MR: Oh that's a wonderful point. That's true. Yeah because you just set it in motion and

JB: Yes.

MR: Wow. There was a period in New York when you were there, it sounded like I think I read you had some, a couple of roommates that shared your passion, Harvie S. and —

JB: Harvie S. He was a young player. I just got through playing with him last night. He just left, right at 1:00 because he stayed over with his wife Yukimi, and they just left going back — or no I think he's hanging with his cousin today. Anyway yeah, so I moved in with Harvie in Rego Park, Queens and he was working with Lee Konitz, Mike Abene, this guy and that. He was working all the time. So people would call him up to do a gig and say, "Hey man you need a tenor player? You need a tenor player?" So he was really helpful. And then I moved into Manhattan with Art Baron who was on the road with Duke Ellington's band right on Sixth Avenue on 819-821 there's a whole documentary called "The Jazz Loft" and where Phil Woods used to go play there and Zoot Sims and all these guys, a generation or two before me, and it was the same place except mine was this window and theirs was that window. I was 821 theirs was 819. And we could play music 24/7.

MR: Did your parents support your obvious bug? Your passion?

JB: No. But they didn't tell me not to. They didn't say yeah man, keep practicing you know. They just went, "This guy's nuts look at him. What's he —" that sort of thing. They just left me alone which is good enough.

MR: And did your gig-playing-uncle get to see you play?

JB: Yes but not really. He wasn't like — I mean he saw me play with Dave Brubeck you know on T.V. or whatever or you know heard me on records and things like that. But he never like came to my gigs or anything like that.

MR: I see.

JB: He wasn't supportive in that way but yeah, just what it was.

MR: Yeah. When you think of Dave Brubeck as a person is there anything you can share with us sort of beyond his music?

JB: He was a devoted family man, even though he was on the road all the time, his kids used to call him "U.D." — Uncle Dave. But yeah, he you know was dedicated to his kids and his wife and, yeah, strong family man.

MR: Later in life there was a lot of spirituality in the things he wrote.

JB: Yeah.

MR: And I would say I got to know, I got to interview him and Iola and I would say they are the very definition of "woke" if we're looking for one.

JB: Yeah.

MR: He did not object to the fact that you played differently than some of his previous

JB: Yes. He never told me once how to play. Not once. He never said yeah I want you to play more like Paul Desmond, who I idolized. I'd like to be able to play like Paul Desmond. Who wouldn't? But that's not the way I played. That's not my personality. Yeah he never told me. And I think he appreciated that. And besides when you think about it, anybody who was into the Paul Desmond camp, you're going to lose because nobody's going to sound as good playing like Paul Desmond as Paul Desmond. Right? So I didn't play anything like that so that's a good thing. You can't compare apples and oranges you know?

MR: Let me ask you about — you do some ensemble work at the New England Conservatory. Do you try to teach some of the things that the jazz bandstand practice, the elements of getting a gig and keeping a gig and bandstand etiquette. Is that something that you can teach in a rehearsal room?

JB: I think you can teach it by setting an example, not by telling somebody. But if you are a serious musician or and also have a good sense of humor, don't take yourself too seriously and not a prima donna, you know, I think those are good examples. I think like you know just the way I treat the people in the ensemble, I treat them the way I would like to be treated. So I'm not shouting at anyone, I'm not like saying, "Hey that was terrible, you call yourself —" you know I don't do any of that stuff. You know I try to encourage them and I'll stop the band and say let's get this together, but it's always in a, with the intention of a positive critique. And I'll even say, "What did you think of that? How did you feel about that?" You know I'll ask them what they think you know. And I tell them we're all musicians here, let's use our group ear to try to get to the what we think is going to make this song or this concert sound good.

MR: What kind of things would happen that you would take a musician off your list. In other words most of us have lists. We get a gig and unless you have an established band then you start calling musicians to play it. Why would you take someone off your list?

JB: Well say I called somebody like three or four times and they can't do the gig. After a while I'm going to stop calling them, because they're just not available. If they don't show up to a gig, if they don't show up twice, if they come in real drunk which hasn't happened really. I mean I can remember once or twice but you know that kind of thing or if they're — but if they don't get along with the other guys in the band. But most of the time I'm hiring people that I already know have a great reputation for that. You know? I mean a good reputation for getting along with people. They're team players so to speak. Yeah.

MR: Do you ever make suggestions to the group? I'm thinking of the fact that if you have a quartet, there's a lot of different possibilities to sound different than a quartet. You could

have bass and saxophone alone, drums and saxophone alone. Do you ever do like instant arranging?

JB: I like it when the group does that, instant like for example I play with some groups and all of a sudden the drummer will just drop out behind me. You know? And it's kind of cool because it surprises you. They didn't tell you they were going to do that, they just do it and you're sitting there and you've got to come up with the goods you know. Or I'll say yeah, I want to start the set with just the bass. Yeah, all of that, to make a music that could be kind of one-dimensional have more dimensions.

MR: Yeah I've noticed that when someone drops out that's one effect and when they come back in that's another effect.

JB: That's another effect.

MR: Yeah. Some people don't think of those kinds of things. They feel like if I'm not playing a lot then I'm not doing my job.

JB: Yeah. And yeah like bass players, you mentioned Harvie S., and I tell Harvie I said, yeah, I really like it that I don't have to tell you when to play in two, when to play broken time, when to walk, when not to walk, when to play open. You know. He just knows when to do it. I don't have to tell him.

MR: Let me run a couple of names by you, if you saw them or if their particular personality or musicianship meant much to you. Cannonball Adderley?

JB: Yes. Man, I remember seeing him with the "Fiddler on the Roof" gig with Charles Lloyd, Joe Zawinul, Sam Jones and Louis Hayes and Nat of course. And I nudged a guy next to me and said, "Man he doesn't move his fingers." He played this real fast thing and like a little twitch like Charlie Parker's. You know like slight of hand movement you know. It just amazed me. Not to mention him talking on the mic and being so positive and uplifting. Yeah. What an — amazing.

MR: How about the Pharoah Sanders and the late John Coltrane, that music that was so filled with — I don't have the word for it — but it was so filled with over-the-top, now I'm getting into where I didn't want to go, so —

JB: Well you know I saw the Coltrane quartet maybe a half dozen times. And with McCoy, Elvin and Jimmy. And one time in 1963 at the Newport Jazz Festival Roy Haynes was there, and it was funny because Count Basie was in the afternoon, Woody Herman, and Coltrane comes on, it's dusk, and people are leaving in droves. They just weren't ready for that type of music. But by the time Pharoah Sanders came in the group I was totally into another kind. I was listening to Miles with Wayne, and I saw that group so many times in all their reincarnations when Jack — when Dave Holland first joined the group, when Chick Corea and Jack DeJohnette — one time I even saw them with Wynton Kelly

Another time I saw them with Joe Henderson and Wayne at Lennie's on the Turnpike. So but when, as I used to see Roland Kirk there and Wynton Kelly Trio and — but I never saw the group with Pharoah play. I saw Pharoah play with his group but I never saw him with John Coltrane. I wish I had.

MR: Well that group, from your four elements, his late recordings, "Ascension" and —

JB: I listened to all the recordings but I never saw them.

MR: Okay. Would you say that he had a preponderance of one of those or two of those elements that you talked about?

JB: Yeah I'd say so.

MR: And what would they be?

JB: I would say fire.

MR: Uh huh.

JB: Fire and water.

MR: Lots of emotion. Yes. That's for sure.

JB: Yeah. Scorched earth fire.

MR: Scorched earth. And one more, what about Hank Mobley?

JB: Never got to see him live.

MR: No.

JB: It's a shame. You know by the time I saw Miles it was with Wayne. And I saw Wayne with Art Blakey and Freddie Hubbard and Curtis Fuller and Jimmy Merritt. Cedar Walton.

MR: Did you ever feel like you were born a little too late?

JB: No.

MR: I'm glad.

JB: I never felt that way. Yeah I don't regret not being around during the heyday of what they — and some people say man don't worry about — there was never a heyday. But I don't regret being born when I was born.

MR: The good old days are now.

JB: Yeah. That's it. Now's the time.

MR: Key of F, isn't it?

JB: Yeah.

MR: What's coming up in the near future for you? You've got the summer off?

JB: No, I've got a gig in Brooklyn Thursday but then I'm coming — I have to go to St. John's Island, I've got a gig up there with Jim Vivian, a great bass player. He got a grant to have me just come up there and do a concert. And then I'm going to Europe to Denmark for two and a half weeks, mostly Denmark. I'm going to Berlin for a couple of

alto player who teaches at McGill, doing a jazz camp in August, Jazz in the Mountains in Vermont, and September — oh June 30 also September 2 and September 4 I'm playing with the Elvin Jones 50th Anniversary of Live at the Lighthouse with Dave Liebman, Gene Perla, Adam Nussbaum. We're playing those tunes from that album.

MR: You have a full plate.

JB: Full plate.

MR: Well I've absolutely enjoyed this conversation and I'm going to have that Pluto thing on my mind.

JB: Just check it out. Pluto — first just go Pluto Return. Then Pluto Return USA. Nobody ever has a Pluto Return in their own chart. You don't live 248 years. But countries have Pluto Returns. So check it out. It's heavy.

MR: All right. Well you're a heavy musician and thank you for sharing what you did today.

JB: Thank you so much, Monk. Appreciate it.

MR: All right. I'll pause us and then we'll say our good-byes.

JB: Okay.